

*By Jaclyn Camden, Christy Stuart, and Jennifer Quinn*

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**What do VR counselors need to know about higher education programs for students with intellectual disability?**

They need to know how enrolling in your program will lead to competitive integrated employment that aligns with the student's interests and goals. They also need to know what programs look for in an applicant so they can determine which of their clients would qualify.

2

**What is an Individual Plan for Employment (IPE) and why is it important to students accessing higher education programs?**

An IPE is a personalized plan developed with a VR counselor that outlines a student's career goals and the specific services and supports needed to reach those goals. VR counselors can't support a student attending the program if their IPE and higher education goals don't align.

3

**How can we help a student and family who want to connect with VR?**

Make a referral or help the student and family access the referral process. In many states, students/families can submit a referral for services online. Then, the VR professional can contact the student and family to gather information and share resources that fit with the student's goals.

4

**My program wants to connect and build a partnership with our VR agency. How do we get started and make first contact with VR?**

Gather information about your state's VR agency and find your local office. Visit their website to understand their mission, services, and contact details. Introduce your program: share how you believe a partnership with VR can be mutually beneficial and share your intent to support students in achieving their employment goals.

5

**Are there opportunities to fund some tuition or housing for students with open VR cases?**

Many VR agencies provide some level of funding to support access to higher education programs that are employment-focused and have good employment outcomes. Reach out to your local VR offices or contact your inclusive higher education alliances to see if there are any standing agreements in your state.

6

**Are there no-cost services available to students in higher education programs?**

Absolutely! Even if a student is not found eligible to receive financial support, VR counselors can provide no-cost services if a student is found eligible for VR services, such as career counseling and guidance, specific types of assessments, and job placement services.

7

**How can VR counselors partner with my program to help students transition out of college and into a career?**

VR counselors can help students connect with job coaching services and program staff connect with employers who may be interested in hiring graduates. They can also help the student and family assess other needs and assist with benefits planning.

8

## What program data points are VR counselors most interested in?

Data that gives insight into students' career readiness and employment outcomes, such as data about: career goals and specific experiences; employer evaluations; career-related skills development; student support services; student satisfaction surveys; enrollment numbers and completion rates of students in the program; and employment and retention rates of graduates.

9

## What is the difference between VR services and pre-employment transition services (pre-ETS), and how can each support higher education programs?

VR agencies provide both types of services. Pre-ETS are available to students with disabilities ages 14–24 who are still in school and focus on preparing students for the transition from school to work. VR services support eligible individuals with disabilities in obtaining, maintaining, and advancing employment. VR can offer vocational assessments, career counseling, job placement assistance, and financial assistance, and provide work-based learning experiences, internships, and job coaching.

10

## What other ways should we involve VR counselors?

You can include VR counselors on the program's advisory board; schedule regular meetings with VR counselors to discuss student progress, program improvements, and alignment with VR goals; provide student semester reports; co-develop and co-host cross-training opportunities to educate VR and program staff on how to best collaborate; invite VR counselors to person-centered planning and other meetings ensuring that educational and career goals are aligned; consult with the VR counselor before making career goal changes; and work together to advocate for policies and resources that support the inclusion and employment of individuals with intellectual disability.

**10** Questions

**Top 10 Questions VR Counselors have for Staff of Higher Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability**

*By Thomas Adams, Loretta Allen, Rebecca Smith, and John Carter*

### Read the “Top 10 Questions VR Counselors have for Staff of Higher Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability.”

- 1** What is a higher education program for students with intellectual disability?
- 2** Why would a student with intellectual disability pursue higher education?
- 3** What does the student with intellectual disability gain from going to college?
- 4** How does attending college help students with intellectual disability prepare for adult employment?
- 5** In higher education employment-related?
- 6** What are the barriers to employment for students with intellectual disability?

**1** What is a higher education program for students with intellectual disability?

A college program where students take courses, do career development activities, and may receive the state award a certificate or credential at a post and a year of higher education.

**2** Why would a student with intellectual disability pursue higher education?

Students with intellectual disability pursue higher education for a variety of reasons. Some students want to learn more about college, higher education programs support students as they work toward a credential and gain student knowledge, skills, and experience get a job in career.

**3** What does the student with intellectual disability gain from going to college?

A wide variety of skills and academic experiences. A student with intellectual disability may learn: workplace readiness skills, independence, decision-making skills, social skills, personal responsibility, and more.

**4** How does attending college help students with intellectual disability prepare for adult employment?

Programs give opportunities for students to explore interests and gain hands-on experience through work-based learning, internships, and other experiences. College helps students in a higher education than they may be used to, which encourages student growth.

**5** In higher education employment-related?

Yes, the goal of these programs is to prepare students for competitive integrated employment. Students receive individualized supports to the academic, employment, and career development activities, the curriculum, post-employment, resource development, and professional networking.

**6** What are the barriers to employment for students with intellectual disability?

Some programs are not designed to support students with intellectual disability. Some programs are not designed to support students with intellectual disability. Some programs are not designed to support students with intellectual disability. Some programs are not designed to support students with intellectual disability.



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